is revealing that the two nations have entered into trilaterals with Australia and the UAE recently.

For India, in recent years, ties with France fit the challenge of ‘right-sizing’ its crucial partners. A nation that espouses the Third Way also holds an intuitive appeal to an independent-minded India. Its autonomy and self-reliance resonate strongly, as does its reticence on bringing in larger concerns. Once the two nations consciously decided to make this a foundation, their collaboration grew steadily over multiple regimes. As a result, in the pursuit of its larger aspirations, India has found in France another significant player committed to multipolarity.

However, while the long-standing insistence by both India and France to maintain their decisional freedom may produce convergences, each will have its own perspective. After all, they are located in very different geographies that will naturally decide both priorities and interests.

Like every other relationship, this one, too, will require assiduous tending. What should give most cause for optimism is that they have actually set out a perspective of cooperation for Horizon 2047.

The P-3 examples of the UK, Russia and France may be contrasting, but they do bring out the intrinsic value of the relationships. The fact is that permanent members of the UNSC have an importance much beyond that body. Nurturing these ties is, therefore, all the more important as India’s interests unfold across the world.

RESETTING WITH THE WEST

Since international relations is simultaneously a collective and national activity, it is perhaps worthwhile to assess India’s approach to the West as a whole. Understandably, some of that remains coloured by the experience of colonialism. That said, it is also a fact that this era has facilitated elite bonding to a considerable degree.

The one Western country that could have escaped the colonial taint was the US. It, however, blotted its copybook in India by strongly aligning with the Pakistani military and, thereafter, with China. These negatives were nevertheless set off against the substantive economic, technological and societal linkages that were built up after India’s independence. Interestingly, even the political frictions were sometimes mitigated by circumstances.